

Communication Skills and Records Management

Course: CS — Certified Secretaries

Level: Foundation Level (CS12)

Last updated: 29 July 2026

Syllabus version: Based on the standard KASNEB CS Foundation Level Communication Skills and Records Management syllabus topics (CS12) — the communication process, business writing, meetings documentation, and records/filing systems. Authored from general communication and records-management knowledge and standard syllabus topic coverage, not copied from any existing notes provider or study guide. Cross-check terminology and emphasis against the current KASNEB syllabus and examiner's reports before the exam.

Original work notice. Every explanation, worked example, and question in this document was written from scratch for this paper. No text has been copied or paraphrased from any KASNEB past paper, textbook, or third-party notes/study guide. The scenarios and practice questions are original.

Contents

1. The communication process and barriers to it
 2. Business letters, memoranda and reports
 3. Meetings and minute-taking
 4. What is records management?
 5. Filing systems and classification methods
 6. The records life cycle
 7. Records retention and disposal
 8. Electronic records management, basics
 9. Full worked question — drafting minutes of a meeting
 10. Practice examination — KASNEB-style paper (original, not a past paper)
 11. Marking guide — model answers to the practice examination
 12. Exam technique and revision checklist
-

1. The communication process and barriers to it

Communication is the process of transmitting a message from sender to receiver so it is understood as intended: sender encodes → transmits via a channel → receiver decodes → feedback confirms understanding. Common barriers: physical (noise), language (jargon), perceptual/psychological (differing assumptions), and organisational (unclear reporting lines).

2. Business letters, memoranda and reports

A **business letter** is formal, typically for external correspondence, with a conventional structure (addresses, salutation, body, complimentary close). A **memorandum** is shorter, typically internal, using a simple To/From/Date/Subject header. A **report** presents information/analysis/recommendations, typically structured as: title, terms of reference, procedure, findings, conclusions/recommendations.

3. Meetings and minute-taking

Key meeting roles: the **chairperson** (leads the meeting, ensures order) and the **secretary** (prepares the agenda, records minutes). A **quorum** is the minimum attendance required for valid business. **Minutes** are the official record of what was discussed and decided, typically including attendance, matters arising, resolutions passed, and actions assigned with a responsible person and deadline.

4. What is records management?

Records management is the systematic control of an organisation's records — their creation, maintenance, use and disposal — ensuring records are accurate, accessible when needed, and retained (or destroyed) in line with legal and organisational requirements. Good records management supports accountability, decision-making, and compliance, while poor records management creates real legal and operational risk (e.g. inability to produce required documents during a dispute or audit).

5. Filing systems and classification methods

Common classification methods: **alphabetical** (by name), **numerical** (by assigned number, often with a separate alphabetical index), **subject** (grouped by topic/matter), and **chronological** (by date). Each has trade-offs: alphabetical filing is intuitive but can suffer from inconsistent naming; numerical filing supports confidentiality (files aren't identifiable by

name alone) but requires an index; subject filing groups related material logically but requires clear, consistently applied categories.

6. The records life cycle

Records typically pass through: **creation** (a record is generated), **active use** (frequently accessed for current business), **semi-active storage** (accessed occasionally, often moved to lower-cost storage), and **disposal** (destruction or permanent archival, per a retention schedule). Managing records deliberately through this life cycle — rather than treating all records as equally "live" indefinitely — keeps active filing systems efficient and storage costs manageable.

7. Records retention and disposal

A **retention schedule** specifies how long different record types must be kept before disposal, based on legal, regulatory, and operational requirements (e.g. tax records typically require longer retention than routine internal correspondence). Records should never be destroyed without reference to an approved retention schedule, since premature disposal can create serious legal exposure if a record is later required for a dispute, audit, or regulatory inquiry.

8. Electronic records management, basics

Electronic records management involves similar principles to physical records — consistent classification, access control, and retention/disposal policy — but adds specific considerations: version control (ensuring the current version is clearly identified), backup and disaster recovery, and information security (protecting confidential records from unauthorised access). A well-designed electronic system should make retrieval faster and more reliable than an equivalent physical system, provided classification and naming conventions are applied consistently.

9. Full worked question — drafting minutes of a meeting

Scenario. A department held a meeting to decide on relocating to a new office floor. Present: 5 members (quorum = 4). It was resolved to proceed with relocation by 30 September, with the facilities officer responsible for coordination.

Required: Draft a short extract of minutes reflecting this decision.

Solution:**MINUTES EXTRACT**

Present: 5 members (quorum of 4 met)

Matter discussed: Proposed relocation to the new office floor.

Resolution: It was resolved that the department shall relocate to the new office floor by **30 September**. The **Facilities Officer** was assigned responsibility for coordinating the relocation and reporting progress at the next meeting.

10. Practice examination — KASNEB-style paper (original, not a past paper)

Note on format. This section is laid out the way a KASNEB CS examination paper is laid out — a timed paper with five compulsory 20-mark questions — purely so you can practise under realistic exam conditions. Every question below is an original scenario written for this document. **It is not a reproduction of any actual KASNEB past examination paper.**

CS FOUNDATION LEVEL — COMMUNICATION SKILLS AND RECORDS MANAGEMENT (PRACTICE PAPER)

TIME ALLOWED: 3 HOURS

Instructions to candidates: Answer ALL FIVE questions. Each question carries 20 marks. Show all workings clearly.

QUESTION ONE

- (a) Describe the communication process. (8 marks)
 - (b) Outline THREE barriers to effective communication. (6 marks)
 - (c) Distinguish between a business letter and a memorandum. (6 marks)
- (Total: 20 marks)
-

QUESTION TWO

- (a) Distinguish between the roles of a chairperson and a secretary in a meeting. (8 marks)
 - (b) Define "quorum" and explain its significance. (6 marks)
 - (c) Outline FOUR items typically recorded in the minutes of a meeting. (6 marks)
- (Total: 20 marks)

QUESTION THREE

(a) Define "records management" and explain its importance to an organisation. *(10 marks)*

(b) Outline FOUR methods of classifying records for filing. *(10 marks)*

(Total: 20 marks)

QUESTION FOUR

(a) Outline the stages of the records life cycle. *(12 marks)*

(b) Explain the purpose of a retention schedule and the risk of destroying records without reference to one. *(8 marks)*

(Total: 20 marks)

QUESTION FIVE

(a) Outline THREE specific considerations relevant to electronic records management beyond those relevant to physical records. *(12 marks)*

(b) Explain why consistent classification and naming conventions matter for effective electronic records retrieval. *(8 marks)*

(Total: 20 marks)

11. Marking guide — model answers to the practice examination

QUESTION ONE

(a) *(8 marks)* — Sender encodes a message → transmits via a channel → receiver decodes it → feedback confirms understanding.

(b) *(6 marks — 2 marks each)* — Physical, language, perceptual/psychological (organisational also acceptable).

(c) *(6 marks)* — A business letter is formal, typically external, with a full structure; a memo is shorter, typically internal, with a simple header.

QUESTION TWO

(a) *(8 marks)* — Chairperson leads the meeting and ensures order/agenda is followed; secretary prepares the agenda and records/circulates minutes.

(b) *(6 marks)* — Quorum is the minimum attendance required for a meeting's business to be validly conducted; without it, decisions may not be procedurally valid.

(c) (6 marks — 1.5 marks each) — Attendance, matters arising, resolutions passed, actions assigned (with responsible person/deadline).

QUESTION THREE

(a) (10 marks) — Records management is the systematic control of records' creation, maintenance, use and disposal; important for accountability, decision-making and legal/regulatory compliance.

(b) (10 marks — 2.5 marks each) — Alphabetical, numerical, subject, chronological.

QUESTION FOUR

(a) (12 marks — 3 marks each) — Creation, active use, semi-active storage, disposal.

(b) (8 marks) — A retention schedule specifies how long records must be kept per legal/regulatory/operational needs; destroying records without reference to it risks serious legal exposure if a record is later required for a dispute, audit, or regulatory inquiry.

QUESTION FIVE

(a) (12 marks — 4 marks each) — Version control, backup/disaster recovery, information security/access control.

(b) (8 marks) — Consistent classification and naming makes records reliably findable by anyone searching the system, rather than only by the person who originally created/named the file, supporting faster, more reliable retrieval organisation-wide.

12. Exam technique and revision checklist

- Meeting-related questions: know the specific roles and terms (chairperson, secretary, quorum, minutes) precisely.
- Records-management "outline" questions: name specific classification methods or life-cycle stages, not a vague general description.
- Retention schedule questions: always mention both the legal/compliance angle and the risk of premature disposal.
- Electronic records questions: distinguish clearly what's *additional* to physical records (version control, backup, security), not just repeat physical-records principles.
- Scenario/minutes questions: always include quorum status, the specific resolution, and the responsible person/deadline where given.

Quick revision — one line per topic:

1. Communication process: sender → encode → channel → receiver → decode → feedback.
2. Business letter (formal, external) vs memo (short, internal).

3. Meeting roles: chairperson (leads), secretary (agenda/minutes). Quorum = minimum valid attendance.
 4. Records management: systematic control of records' creation, use, and disposal.
 5. Filing classification: alphabetical, numerical, subject, chronological.
 6. Records life cycle: creation → active use → semi-active storage → disposal.
 7. Retention schedule: legal/compliance-driven; premature disposal risks legal exposure.
 8. Electronic records add: version control, backup/disaster recovery, security.
-

End of study notes. This document is intended as original exam-preparation material and should be used alongside the current official KASNEB syllabus and examiner's reports for the paper.